PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Wrangler JK (2-door)

2007–2018 · JK

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Which engine? Check the VIN year**
  2007–11 trucks have the 3.8 and the four-speed automatic; 2012-on trucks have the Pentastar and the five-speed. The Pentastar is the one most buyers want. On a 2012–13, ask whether the left cylinder head was ever replaced: Chrysler extended coverage on affected heads to 10 years or 150,000 miles, which has run out on most of them by now.
- [ ] **Look into the engine valley (2012–18)**
  Quadratec says the Pentastar's plastic oil filter housing 'has a bad habit of cracking'. Look for oil pooled under the intake plenum, a burning-oil smell or slow oil loss. Because the housing contains the oil cooler, coolant can leak there too. Many owners fit an aluminum housing.
- [ ] **Jack up the front axle**
  JK ball joints often wear surprisingly quickly, especially with 35s, bumpers and winches. Check for vertical wheel play, steering looseness, uneven tire wear and highway wander. Then drive it at 45–65 mph over bumps to rule out death wobble.
- [ ] **Listen at cold start**
  A tick-tick-tick that fades as the engine warms is usually snapped rear exhaust manifold bolts, which Quadratec calls notorious on both the 3.8 and the 3.6. It isn't urgent, but it's a negotiating point.
- [ ] **Electrical gremlins and water**
  JK electrical faults often trace to the TIPM (Totally Integrated Power Module) or a failing clockspring. Symptoms include airbag lights, dead steering-wheel controls, fuel-pump problems and wipers with a mind of their own. Water in the cabin makes them worse, so lift the carpets and look for damp.
- [ ] **Inspect the front axle C's on modified trucks**
  On 35-inch tires or bigger, hard use can bend the Dana 30's C-shaped knuckle ends where the ball joints sit. Look for odd camber, strange tire wear and whether gusset plates or a truss are already fitted.
- [ ] **Prove the Rubicon hardware works**
  Engage both lockers and the sway-bar disconnect, and confirm 4-Low is the 4:1 Rock-Trac. A Moab or Willys Wheeler looks the part but has the 2.72:1 transfer case, and lockers were optional at best.
- [ ] **Read the lift like a résumé**
  Most JKs are modified. A quality lift should include a correct track bar, geometry correction and an alignment. Cheap spacer lifts with 35s are where worn joints and death wobble come from.

YEARS TO KNOW

2007	BEWARE	JK launch (production from August 2006): 3.8 EGH V6 (202 hp) with a 6-speed manual or 4-speed 42RLE auto; Rubicon has Dana 44s with lockers, 4:1 Rock-Trac and a sway-bar disconnect; the four-door Unlimited is new. First-year trucks drew several recalls

		(SlashGear), 2007–08 log the most complaints on CarComplaints.com (CarGurus), and Driving Line warns the 3.8 burns oil, leaks intake gaskets and cracks exhaust manifolds
2012	SWEET SPOT	3.6 Pentastar V6 (285 hp, 260 lb-ft) and 5-speed W5A580 automatic replace the 3.8 and the 4-speed. The Pentastar is the engine to have (Quadratec, Driving Line); Driving Line's daily-driver pick is a 2013 or newer

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Driver airbag clockspring**
  2007–2010 · NHTSA 16V-290
- ☐ **Takata passenger airbag inflator**
  2007–2012 · NHTSA 16V-352
- ☐ **Takata passenger inflator (Zone A states)**
  2009–2013 · NHTSA 18V-021
- ☐ **Driver airbag inflator**
  2010–2016 · NHTSA 19V-018
- ☐ **Automatic transmission overheat warning**
  2007–2008 · NHTSA 09V-436
- ☐ **Front brake lines vs inner fender liner**
  2007–2010 · NHTSA 10V-236
- ☐ **Axle-to-chassis fastener torque**
  2010–2011 · NHTSA 11V-145
- ☐ **Power-steering line rubs transmission cooler tube**
  2012–2013 · NHTSA 13V-234
- ☐ **Heated mirror connector short**
  2011–2013 · NHTSA 14V-631
- ☐ **Front impact sensor wiring**
  2016–2017 · NHTSA 16V-734

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Real Rubicon**
  Dana 44 axles front and rear with Tru-Lok electronic lockers, Rock-Trac transfer case with 4:1 low range, 4.10 gears and an electronic sway-bar disconnect switch. Sport and Sahara trucks have Command-Trac with 2.72:1 low range.
- ☐ **Axles by trim**
  Sport (X) and Sahara have a Dana 30 front and a Dana 44 rear; Quadratec says fewer than a thousand early 2007s got a Dana 35 rear instead (its 2007 spec table lists the Dana 35 for the X). Rubicon has Dana 44s at both ends. A rear locker was optional on X and Sahara for 2007, then on select X models for 2008–2009.
- ☐ **Engine and year**
  2007–2011 trucks have the 3.8 EGH V6 (4-speed 42RLE auto or 6-speed manual). 2012–2018 trucks have the 3.6 Pentastar (5-speed W5A580 auto or 6-speed manual). 2011 got the new interior a year before the new engine.
- ☐ **Moab and Rubicon X**
  The 2013 Moab has AEV-style bumpers and hood but keeps the 2.72:1 transfer case. The 2014 Rubicon X keeps the full Rubicon drivetrain and adds steel bumpers and a Power Dome hood.
- ☐ **2018 JK vs JL**
  2018 JKs sold alongside the new JL carry a 'Wrangler JK' decal on the front fenders.

NOTES

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